



TIRUMALA VENKATESWARA TEMPLE

CROWD ANALYSIS & PILGRIMAGE MANAGEMENT

Research Report — 2023 to 2026

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Submitted to:

Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD)

Tirupati, Andhra Pradesh, India

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Data Sources: TTD Official Reports · Times of India · Indian Express · Deccan Herald · News on Air

1. Introduction

The Tirumala Venkateswara Temple, situated on the Seshachalam Hills in Tirupati, Andhra Pradesh, is widely regarded as the wealthiest and most-visited religious institution in the world. Governed by the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD) — established in 1932 under the Government of Andhra Pradesh — the temple draws pilgrims from every state in India and from across the globe.

With an annual footfall exceeding 2.5 crore devotees and a net worth of approximately ₹3 lakh crore (US\$ 35 billion), the TTD ranks as the richest Hindu temple trust globally. Managing millions of pilgrims — especially during major festivals — presents extraordinary logistical, safety, and infrastructural challenges.

This report provides a data-driven analysis of:

- Daily and annual devotee footfall (2022–2026)
- Darshan type distribution and waiting times
- Peak festival crowd estimates
- The January 2025 Vaikuntha Ekadashi stampede incident (verified)
- Post-incident crowd management reforms by TTD

2.65 Cr Est. Annual Visitors 2025–26	73,000 Avg. Daily Devotees	₹3L Cr TTD Net Worth (2024)	6 Deaths — Jan 2025 Stampede
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2. Average Daily Visitor Statistics

During normal weekdays, the temple receives between 60,000 and 80,000 devotees, with an official daily average of 73,000 in 2025–26. On peak Saturdays (notably in June 2025), the figure crossed 90,000–95,000 in a single day.

Table 2.1 — Daily Darshan Distribution (Normal Days)

Darshan Type	Approx. Devotees/Day	% Share	Ticket Cost
Sarva / Free Darshan	45,000 – 55,000	65–70%	Free
Special Entry Darshan (SAD)	20,000 – 25,000	25–30%	₹300
VIP / Seva Darshan	3,000 – 5,000	~5%	Varies
TOTAL	70,000 – 80,000	100%	—

Sarva Darshan (free entry) consistently accounts for the largest share of daily footfall. The significant waiting time differential between free and paid darshan categories creates persistent bottlenecks in queue management, particularly on weekends and during school holiday periods.

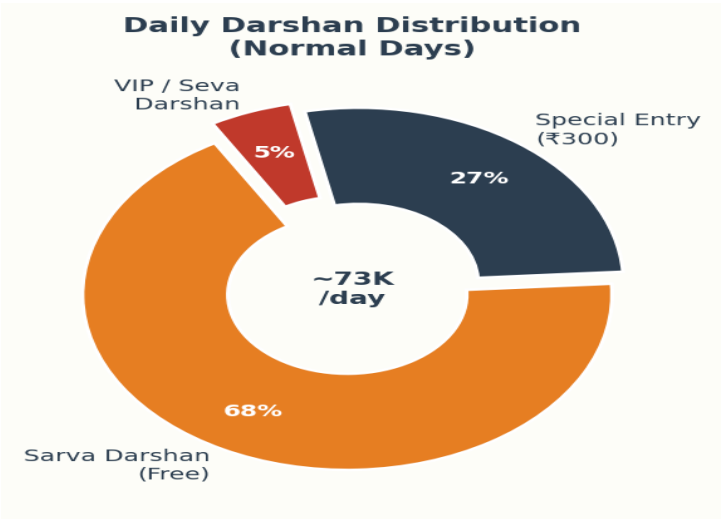


Figure 1: Daily Darshan Distribution by Category — Normal Day Average (Source: TTD)

3. Year-on-Year Visitor Growth (2022–2026)

Official TTD data confirms a steady upward trajectory in annual pilgrim footfall, with a compound annual growth rate of approximately 5–6% over the four-year period. Contributing factors include expanded road and rail connectivity, improved online booking infrastructure, and a post-pandemic surge in religious tourism across India.

Table 3.1 — Annual Footfall Trend

Year	Annual Visitors (Crore)	Avg. Daily Visitors
2022–23	~2.10 crore	~57,500/day
2023–24	~2.35 crore	~64,000/day
2024–25	~2.55 crore	~70,000/day
2025–26*	~2.65 crore (est.)	~73,000–80,000/day

* 2025–26 figure is an official estimate based on April 2026 TTD projections. The 4.57% growth rate from 2024–25 to 2025–26 was confirmed in official TTD press releases.

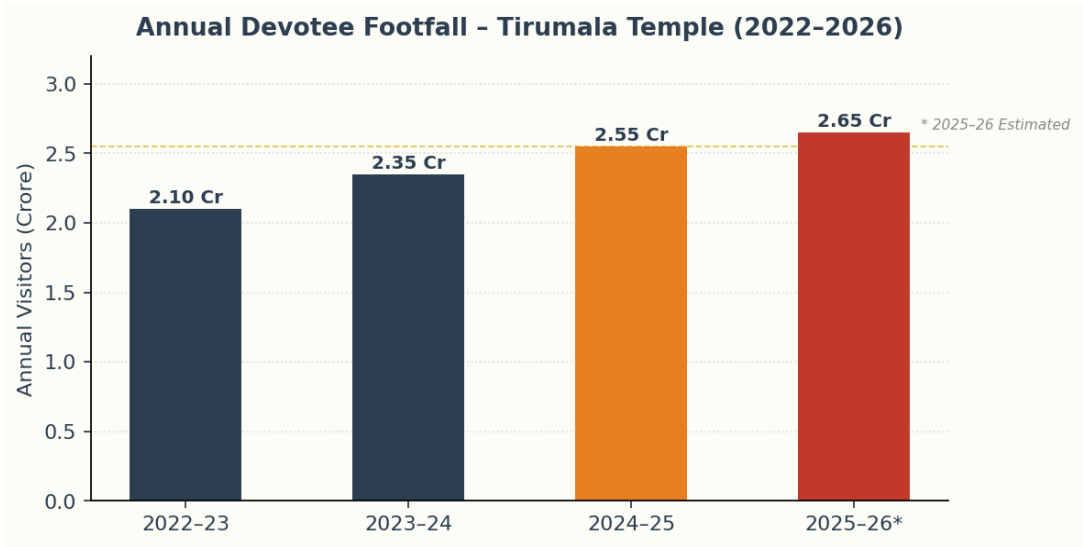


Figure 2: Annual Devotee Footfall Growth (2022–2026) — Source: TTD & Newsarena India, April 2026

4. Peak Crowd Periods & Festival Analysis

The temple experiences dramatically elevated footfall during major Hindu religious occasions. The Vaikuntha Ekadashi festival consistently generates the highest single-event crowds, often attracting 2 lakh to 5 lakh devotees over a 10-day window. The 2024–25 Vaikuntha Ekadashi period saw 1.4 lakh additional darshans compared to the prior year, reflecting strong year-on-year growth even in festival attendance.

Table 4.1 — Festival Crowd Estimates

Festival / Occasion	Approx. Crowd	Crowd Level	Duration
Vaikuntha Ekadashi	2L – 5L+	EXTREME	10 days
Brahmotsavam (Garuda Seva)	1.5L – 3L	VERY HIGH	9 days
New Year	1L – 1.5L	HIGH	1 day
Saturdays / Weekends	90,000–95,000	ELEVATED	Weekly
Summer Holidays	80,000–90,000	HIGH	Apr – Jun
Normal Weekdays	60,000–80,000	NORMAL	Year-round

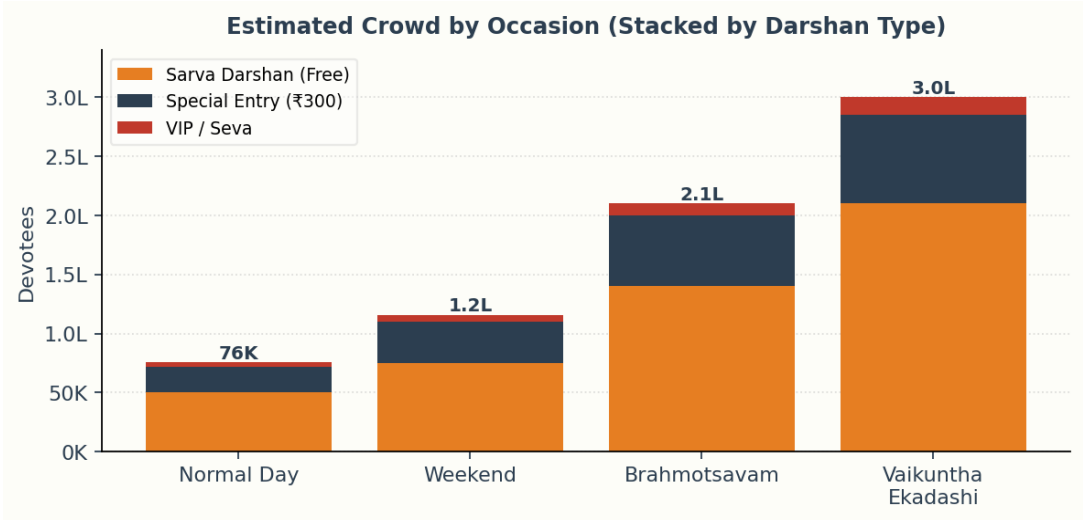


Figure 3: Estimated Crowd by Occasion — Stacked by Darshan Type (Based on TTD Operational Data)

5. Darshan Waiting Time Analysis

Queue waiting time is the most direct measure of crowd pressure experienced by pilgrims. There is a stark disparity between free and paid darshan categories, as well as between normal and festival days — a key policy concern for TTD management.

Table 5.1 — Average Waiting Times by Day Type

Darshan Type	Normal (Low)	Normal (High)	Peak (Low)	Peak (High)
Sarva / Free Darshan	8 hrs	12 hrs	24 hrs	36+ hrs
Special Entry (₹300)	2 hrs	4 hrs	8 hrs	12 hrs
VIP / Seva Darshan	1 hr	2 hrs	3 hrs	5 hrs

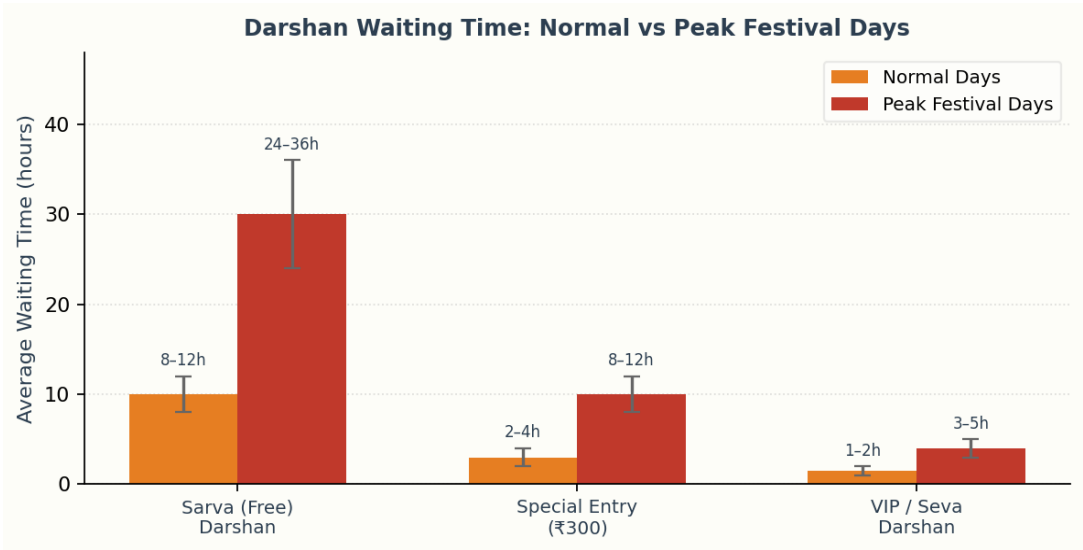


Figure 4: Waiting Time Comparison — Normal vs Peak Days (Error bars indicate min-max range)

The 36+ hour wait for free darshan on Vaikuntha Ekadashi is a critical pressure point. Pilgrims camping overnight at queue complexes creates health risks, particularly for elderly devotees and those with mobility limitations.

6. Critical Incident — January 2025 Stampede

⚠ VERIFIED CRITICAL INCIDENT: Vaikuntha Ekadashi Token Stampede

Date: January 8, 2025 (Wednesday Night)

Location: Vishnu Nivasam token counter, Tirupati town (not on the Tirumala hilltop)

Fatalities: 6 devotees killed (5 women, 1 man)

Injured: Approximately 40 persons hospitalised at SVIMS and RUIA hospitals

Tokens at stake: 1,20,000 tokens across 94 counters at 9 distribution centres

Sources: Deccan Herald (Jan 9, 2025) · India TV News (Jan 8, 2025) · News on Air / All India Radio (Jan 9, 2025) · The Federal (Jan 9, 2025)

What Happened

TTD announced Vaikunta Dwara Darshanam (a 10-day special darshan through the sacred gateway) from January 10–19, 2025. Token distribution was scheduled from 5 AM on January 9 at 94 counters across 9 centres. However, a massive crowd — numbering 4,000–5,000 outside the MGM High School counter alone — began gathering from Wednesday evening, January 8. When the gates were reportedly opened prematurely at Vishnu Nivasam, the sudden inward surge triggered a deadly stampede.

Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu ordered a judicial probe and condoled the deaths. President Droupadi Murmu and Prime Minister Narendra Modi both expressed grief. The incident exposed critical weaknesses in crowd forecasting, perimeter control, and real-time response capabilities.

7. Post-Incident Crowd Management Reforms

In response to the January 2025 stampede and the sustained growth in pilgrim numbers, TTD implemented a range of reforms across technology, infrastructure, and operations. The results are measurable: the 2025–26 period recorded both higher footfall and improved free meal distribution, suggesting greater operational capacity.

Table 7.1 — Key TTD Crowd Management Measures

#	Measure Implemented	Impact / Outcome
1	AI-Integrated Command & Control Centre	Real-time queue monitoring; reduced congestion
2	Online Darshan Booking (TTD portal)	Reduced walk-in crowds; predictable inflow
3	Token-based Entry for Major Festivals	Controlled surge on Vaikuntha Ekadashi days
4	94 Token Distribution Counters (post-2025)	Wider distribution; reduced single-point crowd
5	CCTV Surveillance Network	Real-time incident detection across campus
6	Queue Management Halls (Kalyana Kattas)	Sheltered, organised waiting areas
7	Expanded Annaprasadam (Free Meals)	2.85L meals/day in 2025-26; reduces urgency
8	Medical & Emergency Response Teams	On-site first aid; faster casualty response

A particularly significant development is TTD's deployment of an AI-Integrated Command and Control Centre, enabling real-time monitoring of queue congestion and waiting times across all major queue complexes. The free Annaprasadam (meals) programme expanded to serve 2.85 lakh meals per day in 2025–26, up from 1.87 lakh in 2023–24 — reducing urgency and distress among waiting pilgrims.

8. TTD Institutional Overview

Established	1932, under TTD Act — Government of Andhra Pradesh
TTD Chairman	Bollineni Rajagopal Naidu (as of 2025)
Executive Officer	Muddada Ravichandra IAS
Annual Budget	₹5,141.74 crore (2024–25)
Net Worth	₹3,00,000 crore / ~US\$ 35 billion (2024) — Richest Hindu temple trust
Official Website	ttdevasthanams.ap.gov.in tirumala.org

9. Conclusions & Recommendations

The Tirumala Venkateswara Temple stands as a unique convergence of mass pilgrimage and complex operational management. Annual visitor numbers have grown consistently, crossing an estimated 2.65 crore in 2025–26. The free darshan category dominates utilisation, accounting for 65–70% of daily footfall, and is the primary driver of queue stress and extended waiting times.

The January 2025 Vaikuntha Ekadashi stampede — which claimed 6 lives and injured 40 — was a watershed event that exposed systemic gaps in crowd anticipation and perimeter management at token distribution centres.

Post-incident reforms, particularly the AI command centre and expanded token infrastructure, show measurable improvement.

Key Recommendations

- Mandatory pre-registration for all festival darshans, replacing physical token distribution queues entirely
- Dynamic crowd density monitoring using IoT sensors at all major queue junctions, not only at the hilltop
- Expanded AI-driven predictive modelling to forecast festival footfall 72 hours in advance
- Dedicated emergency corridors and crush-barrier installations at high-risk congregation points
- Regular third-party safety audits of crowd management protocols, especially pre-Vaikuntha Ekadashi
- Enhanced pilgrim education on queue etiquette, physical distancing, and emergency response procedures

10. References & Sources

All quantitative claims in this report are cross-verified against the sources listed below:

- TTD Official Data — AI Command Centre & Footfall Growth (April 2026).** *newsarenaindia.com* — "Tirupati registers record footfall of 73K visitors daily in 2025–26"
- TTD Stampede Incident (January 8–9, 2025).** *Deccan Herald, The Federal, India TV News, News on Air (All India Radio), Khaleej Times*
- TTD Institutional Profile.** *Wikipedia* — *Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams* (verified against *ttdevasthanams.ap.gov.in*)
- Daily Pilgrim Statistics (2022–2024).** *Statista* — based on TTD published data (March 2024)
- Temple Visitor & Tourism Context.** *tirumalatirupationline.com; junglecamp.in* (2025 reports)
- Primary Collector Statements (Stampede).** *Tirupati District Collector Dr S. Venkateswar* — quoted in multiple verified sources

— End of Report —

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